Effect of Consumption of Dried California Mission Figs on Lipid Concentrations

Background Figs are a rich source of soluble fiber. We evaluated the effect of consuming dried California Mission figs on serum lipids in hyperlipidemic adults. Methods In a crossover trial men and women aged 30–75 years with elevated low-density lipoprotein cholesterol (100–189 mg/dl) were randomized to add dried California Mission figs (120 g/day) to their usual diet for 5 weeks or eat their usual diet for 5 weeks, then crossed over to the other condition for another 5 weeks. Six 24-hour dietary recalls were obtained. Results Low- and high-density lipoprotein cholesterol and triglyceride concentrations did not differ between usual and figs-added diets (Bonferroni-corrected $p > 0.017$), while total cholesterol tended to increase with fig consumption ($p = 0.02$). Total cholesterol increased in participants ($n = 41$) randomized to usual followed by figs-added diet ($p = 0.01$), but remained unchanged in subjects ($n = 42$) who started with figs-added followed by usual diet ($p = 0.4$). During the figs-added diet, soluble fiber intake was 12.6 ± 3.7 versus 8.2 ± 4.1 g/day in the usual diet ($p < 0.0001$). Sugar intake increased from 23.4 ± 6.5 to 32.2 ± 6.3% of kcal in the figs-added diet ($p < 0.0001$). Body weight did not change ($p = 0.08$). Conclusions Daily consumption of figs did not reduce low-density lipoprotein cholesterol. Triglyceride concentrations were not significantly changed despite an increase in sugar intake.